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Participatory Budgeting: How Do We Understand Exceptional Democracy?

The scholarship of participatory budgeting

> Today, dozens of regular forums and councils discuss nearly every area of local decisionmaking. Seminars, conferences, and community meetings in which state officials and citizens discuss and decide together on issues ranging from street lighting to economic development policy are an everyday occurrence. Civic groups outside the state-sponsored participatory structure – ranging from innumerable neighbourhood associations to a powerful Urban Reform Movement – have bloomed in the context of political opportunity. (Abers, 2000: 217)

So wrote Rebecca Abers in the first book-length scholarly account of PB in Porto Alegre to be published in the English language: *Inventing Local Democracy* (2000). This summary is striking and inspiring because few people would recognize such a description as normal in their experience of municipal governance. It offers, perhaps, a real example of what might otherwise be seen as radical and sometimes utopian theories (Fung and Wright, 2003). More than 20 years on, a distinct yet diverse body of work has emerged analysing the various effects of PB in Porto Alegre, the diffusion of this innovation across the world, and lately, the different outcomes in different cases of its implementation. But given that attempts to do politics differently are not uncommon (Smith, 2005), why did this phenomenon that began

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in this city capture the imagination of so many? What is it, and what is unique about it? And why are broader comparative analyses so rare?

Chapter 1 showed that there are low-bar definitions of PB that are inclusive of any and all participation in public budgeting, where someone or some group decide to call what is being done 'participatory budgeting'. PB has had its dalliances with fashion in public policy in different contexts, and the labelling of processes can be an issue of some contention for onlookers and participants alike. Calling a process PB says little about levels of citizen control. PB is a renowned democratic innovation because in its ideal type it promises a tangible increase in democratic legitimacy, and subsequently, a more equitable redistribution of goods. Ideal PB enables increased popular control over elements of budgets by institutionalizing citizens' participation in making spending decisions. It exemplifies a successful materialization of participatory political theory into institutional design by encouraging open and diverse participation, allowing 'ordinary citizens' to create, shape and renew institutions and rule-structures themselves. Much of the design of PB has common tenets with Athenian democratic practices and principles in realizing democratic goods (Smith, 2009). In ideal PB this exceptional scale of deep, public participation is combined with structured deliberation and design-rules that limit the threat of co-option and capture by powerful vested interests, resisting the evolution of new elites.

PB is a relatively young phenomenon, its inception now generally traced to the late 1980s in the Brazilian municipality of Porto Alegre, although similar participatory experiments had been undertaken in other Brazilian cities around the same time (Gilman, 2016: 25). Defining PB, even in one city, is no easy task. Take Porto Alegre: a concise definition would need to negotiate the emphases that different observers place on different aspects of the case. Like many things, the procedures and the success of PB in Porto Alegre were the product of a mixture of design, hard work and accident. Even so, it remains the template on which the Workers' Party (Partido dos Trabalhadores, or PT) later introduced PB in several Brazilian municipalities and some federal states. Governing parties from across the political spectrum then introduced PB in various Brazilian municipalities, as well as in other states. The programme's historical roots are indelibly linked to the PT, yet its instigation, promotion and facilitation has continued in the participatory policies of many parties. The programme's success also owes a debt to Brazilian cultures of organized participation that preceded democratization, flourished after for some time, and despite recent retrenchment, continues to have strong foundations in large

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parts of that society. Yet, unlike almost all other ideas of the same generation that show similar democratic potential, this innovation has become institutionalized in many diverse locations, and has diffused rapidly across municipal, national and cultural borders. Diffusion has come through numerous channels with many significant IGOs and NGOs advocating for PB in various forms. The experiences and results of its adaptation to other decision-making venues have been highly differentiated (Sintomer et al, 2008, 2010, 2013, 2016; Dias, 2018).

Wampler (2007b) summarizes the key components of PB based on the original Brazilian model as concisely as possible. He notes that the 'guiding tenets' are: a municipality divided into regions; the provision of budget information by the government and the facilitation of regular meetings at various stages of the budget cycle for deliberation and election of delegates; a 'quality of life' index based on technical criteria used to redistribute resources based on need; a 'bus caravan of priorities' in which elected delegates visit all project sites; a municipal council made up of two councillors per region; a right to veto the budget for the municipal legislature; and regional committees elected to monitor the implementation of projects (2007b: 26). Avritzer, more abstractly, yet more concisely, emphasizes four characteristics: the delegation of sovereignty to regional assemblies; the combination of direct and representative participation; self-regulation; and the 'inversion' of priorities by technical criteria to favour redistribution (2006: 623–4). Other features that could be added to definitions might include outreach to disadvantaged groups by government in promoting participation and reorganization of bureaucracies to prioritize and implement projects, to name just a few.

There is some consensus, then, on where PB has come from and what it is. Although the Porto Alegre model may be the inspiration for programmes, PB has necessarily been implemented in different ways in different contexts. Years of working with policymakers have taught me that it is not uncommon after explaining the ins and outs of complicated processes to hear them reply, 'Yes, but we are already doing that here.' Often these policymakers are deceiving the listener, and often they are also deceiving themselves, but quite often, too, they are on or close to the mark. Very similar participatory processes have grown in different local and national contexts that perhaps differ only in name or in the presence or absence of some key components. Sometimes researchers who build their careers on finding differences too quickly deny the possibility of similarities, as much as researchers who focus on finding similarities gloss over important differences too quickly.

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We are biased as analysts, but our training ought to allow us to reduce that bias. Although PB has changed and adapted, and sometimes been adopted in different ways, that variance presents researchers aiming to explain a phenomenon with an important resource. George and Bennett put it well: 'when explanations for the outcome of individual cases vary, the results can be cumulated and contribute to the development of a rich differentiated theory about that phenomenon' (2005: 216). This sounds a simple statement, but it is surprising how little cumulation takes place and how difficult it can be. It is within the study of PB that the most interesting examples of comparative work on democratic innovations have emerged. In order to contribute to a rich and differentiated theory, I now trace the developments in PB scholarship on which I later build.

Starting from a single case: Porto Alegre, Brazil

Our understanding of a class of phenomena called democratic innovations and/or PB, and therefore of what cases make up that class, evolves over time. That again may seem obvious, but it is important for those interested in cumulation and interpretation of earlier work to keep in mind that earlier studies of a phenomenon can only have intuitions, but never firm knowledge, about what their cases will look like to those classifying them much later (Ryan, 2019). The natural starting point for any significant phenomenon that appears to observers quite new or different in comparison to known phenomena is, to begin with, an ethnographic study. Abers described her approach to an in-depth study of the Porto Alegre case as follows:

> On the first trip I discovered that Porto Alegre was the only PT administration at the time around which there was widespread consensus that participatory policy had been successful at mobilizing people and at actually giving participants real deliberative power. This consensus led me to choose that city as an "exemplary" case of a successful participatory policy. (2000: 230)

Baiocchi saw the contribution of his empirical research on Porto Alegre to theory development in similar terms:

> … the case study of a relevant or unique case can allow for theoretical innovation because of its attention to process and anomaly … as an instance of state–civil society relations,

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> [Porto Alegre] forces us to *rethink theory*. (2005: 165; original emphasis)

Their selection-logic is sound, and shows the need for awareness of background theory, other cases and conditions is an important part of any good case study. Lazy criticism of case study researchers tends to elide this inalienable feature of the case study process.

These first observers identified Porto Alegre as an extreme or unique case of 'participatory policy' or 'state–civil society relations'. The extensive observations and interviews carried out by both Baiocchi and Abers rely on multi-method approaches to data collection with a focus on the advantages of ethnography in exposing in detail the conditions underlying unusual phenomena. They provide good insights into the relationship between politics, administrative reform and civil society activism. Gret and Sintomer (2005) take a slightly more top-down, theory-led case study approach, focusing on how the innovative practices developed in Porto Alegre relate to a wide range of broader political, social and critical theories. Still, this allows them to make important observations about the theoretical relationship between direct and representative democracy in the light of the case; for example, they consider how lot and referenda favoured by many theorists of democratic reform are less familiar as devices for guaranteeing democratic equality in Porto Alegre (2005: 133). These three book-length studies represent the first academic treatments of PB in Porto Alegre to appear in the English language (one translated from French). They are complemented by detailed articles based on their own first-hand research by Santos (2005)[1] and Goldfrank (2003).

The extensive theory-informed descriptive data are important because, to put it in Baiocchi's own words, they 'sought to contribute to the already extensive discussion of democratic theory through an actual examination of instances of popular participation in government decision making' (2005: 142). This greater emphasis on empirics in participatory democracy becomes increasingly common in research that started to appear in the 21st century. Those *actual examinations* of cases of democratic innovation were, at least until the 2010s, all too rare. There are some notable early exceptions – examples include Bryan (2004) and Mansbridge (1983) on town meetings, Davies et al's investigation of NICE's Citizen's Council (2006), Warren and

[1] An earlier version of that research was also published in *Politics & Society* (1998), 26(4), 461–510.

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Pearse's edited collection examining the Citizens' Assembly in British Columbia that took place in 2006 (2008), and Fishkin's (1996) and Dienel's (1989) accounts of their own designs – Deliberative Opinion Polls® and Planning Cells respectively.

These numerous in-depth case studies are invaluable. Methodologists sometimes argue that multiple case studies of a single case can provide something close to replication, with the advantages of corroboration and triangulation. The dispersion and reach of in-depth knowledge on the Porto Alegre case also provides a useful yardstick for calibrating comparisons of other cases among several disparate researchers. The different theoretical lenses used to interpret the empirical data in the case study also highlight the possibilities of alternate adaptations and combinations of democratic devices with PB and within PB, something that is later picked up on by Smith (2009: 190). I continue to argue that case studies and the accumulation of case studies can provide advantages for creativity and novel interpretation as well as testing the evidence for prevailing, bounded assumptions. I return to a discussion of sequencing democratic innovations and devices in the concluding parts of the book. With greater collaboration and consolidation of the field, and improved networks, technologies and methodologies for research, larger-N studies of democratic innovations have become possible. Many challenges in establishing validity when using samples remain when working with this rapidly evolving caseload (see Gastil et al, 2017; Spada and Ryan, 2017; Ryan, 2019), and a discussion of the development of PB scholarship in line with the emergence of new cases and research strategies will highlight some of the trade-offs. The story starts with understanding how Porto Alegre compares to what went before and after.

What made Porto Alegre exceptional?

Porto Alegre is a sprawling metropolis perched on a large lagoon at the southern end of Brazil, and could be described as a relatively unremarkable city at a superficial level. It is a relatively well-off city by the standards of middle-income countries, and has been so by Brazilian standards. It certainly boasts excellent restaurants – you will probably see some chimarrão drinking, and further befitting of Brazilian culture, it has produced one world footballer of the year. Its politics is lively, and frequently unavoidable in a quite literal sense, with politics often taking place out in the streets through a dense, organized and loud civil society. But for those interested in deeper forms of political participation and alternative forms of democracy, Porto Alegre has,

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or had for a time at least,[2] taken on a real symbolic quality as a place where ideas for change found practical success.

Porto Alegre stands out even among the Southern Brazilian cities with longer histories of activism, and some of Brazil's culture and practices of participatory decision-making in politics long predate formal democratization at the federal level (Pogrebinschi and Samuels, 2014; Lüchmann and Borba, 2018: 90). PB-like practices were emerging in some other cities around the same time (Wampler, 2007a). Nevertheless, Porto Alegre, partly due to the vivid successes of its programme, and partly through the strength of its role in international diffusion in both established and novel fora such as the World Social Forum, came to be understood as the archetypal process.

Ethnography is not often suited to parsimonious accounts that rigidly distinguish and index variables for systematic comparison. Describing rich complexity to evoke novel and often-creative insight is its strength. The attention to detail of the early accounts highlights numerous conditions and processes that have ostensibly made the key contributions to the exceptional outcomes in this case. How did these field researchers interpret this Porto Alegre exception?

Both Baiocchi and Abers focus on a change in state–civil society relations as a key condition of interest (in writing up at least, if they may have begun with a more grounded approach). This interest speaks to theories that focus on the necessity of organized, combative civil society organization for holding government to account in functioning democratic polities. Baiocchi suggests that under specific conditions, combative civil society can be bolstered and perhaps even incarnated by state action (2005: 145). For Baiocchi, what was interesting about the Porto Alegre experiment was that for the first time demands from civil society were decoupled from political allegiance (2005: 138). For PB to succeed, it was of the utmost importance that the PT administration helped create an institutional space where both social movements and unorganized citizens could participate on an equal footing (2005: 150; see also Ganuza and Baiocchi, 2012, 2019). Although the party, in this case the PT, may have had an instrumental goal of creating strong grassroots support, it gambled on achieving this through a long-term commitment to participatory ideology and institutionalizing the

[2] After becoming successively more fragile following the removal of PT from the executive in 2004, with the arrival of Porto Alegre's latest new mayor, Nelson Marchezan Júnior in 2017, PB was eventually suspended amid escalating financial and political crises in Brazil (see Nuñez, 2018). Porto Alegre now has an online citizen consultation process that draws some inspiration from PB.

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devolution of power. This involved significant commitment to change in the face of potential political barriers. The government took on a complete reorganization of the planning bureaucracy and increased the municipal tax-take (Santos, 2005: 328). There are also vivid accounts of the very uncertain beginnings and many failures and troubles that greeted the PT's participatory agenda in the early years (see Goldfrank, 2003). Strong resolve in rejecting pressure to resort to old ways of doing political business were required (Baiocchi and Ganuza, 2016). Perhaps the most important lesson for us from these studies of Porto Alegre is that of the commitment needed for the institutionalization of participatory innovations.

Abers explains that over time the introduction of PB in Porto Alegre resulted in a virtuous cycle whereby increased mobilization and the reduction of inequalities gradually augmented one another, benefiting from a political commitment to support meaningful participation and execute priorities decided on and written into the participatory budget (2000: 218). Mobilization of groups that had not previously been organized is of central importance in her account. Abers also submits that these groups flourished and were not co-opted. Her work provides a degree of empirical evidence to refute the considerable scepticism in the literature towards forms of top-down mobilization. In Porto Alegre the government acted as an 'external agent' in the same way as NGOs have traditionally done to mobilize movements. What is more, by implementing participants' decisions, mobilization was increased almost exponentially in the first few years via these 'demonstration effects' (2000: 138). As Goldfrank explains, 'participants could point out to their neighbours and friends the very projects that they had prioritised the year before … compared with 1990, participation in the 1991 budget assemblies more than tripled' (2003: 39).

It is important to remember that the gains in Porto Alegre were not just seen in greater inputs to the political system. Participation was an important part of an effective administration. Many scholars of democratic innovations have preoccupied themselves with the internal workings of deliberative fora. They pay lip service to the need for evaluation of effects in implementation rather than performing analysis (Pogrebinschi and Ryan, 2018). In Porto Alegre, Goldfrank reports that of those involved in the participatory budget he interviewed, 'all could name various public works projects that they and their neighbours had demanded' (2011: 232). PB wasn't just about people feeling good that they had talked about a difficult issue, learned a bit about it and then gone home (the latter is unfortunately the case with many but far from all mini-publics). PB in Porto Alegre meant streets being paved

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to open access to transportation and the economic possibilities going with it; sanitation and health increasing by placing open sewage into pipes – meaning a twelvefold increase in sewage treatment in a short number of years; legalizing squatters' claims to land to improve housing; and building schools, hospitals and clinics (Goldfrank, 2011: 232–3). Importantly, PB in Porto Alegre (and in some other places, as we shall see) shows that following through with the hard slog of democratic participation can have transformative consequences.

Porto Alegre possessed a distinctively vibrant civil society during the last years of the military dictatorship (Santos, 2005: 313). When PB struggled in its first two years, the willingness and capacity of civil society activists to defend the process but challenge the execution of it at the expense of the mayoral administration's public reputation was a key factor in stimulating the structural changes described previously (Goldfrank, 2003: 35–7). What is of interest here is the role played by an autonomous umbrella group representing civil society across neighbourhoods in the city. The Porto Alegre Union of Neighbourhood Associations (UAMPA) is where the idea and impetus for community control over municipal finances can be first recognized (Avritzer, 2005: 386; Ganuza and Baiocchi, 2012: 3). Both Baiocchi and Abers stress that UAMPA later declined and was, in effect, replaced by PB. Rather than mobilize existing PT sympathizers, PB in Porto Alegre mobilized PT sympathy by providing for new groups (Wampler, 2007a: 125). We get a sense from these accounts that PB really was transforming how politics was done, and how the state interacted with citizens in the city. Baiocchi's comparison of districts within Porto Alegre's PB structure allows him to conclude that 'pre-existing civic networks were not found necessary to ensure the routinization of the process, and in fact, very strong associations proved a stumbling block', for example, in the Norte region (2005: 138). Nevertheless, urban associations still became the primary sources of information on matters to do with PB (Gret and Sintomer, 2005: 84). These discussions of Porto Alegre have orientated the investigations of interested observers of other PB successes and failures. Later comparativists have taken up and identified the history of organized combative civil society activism, for example, as pertinent to successes in their accounts (see, for example, Wampler, 2008).

A further important contribution to the successful appeal of the Porto Alegre case comes in the development of rules that encouraged participants to put themselves in others' shoes. Rules matter in shaping how and what we decide, and, as Smith and Wales succinctly put it, 'preferences are not exogenous to institutional setting' (2000: 52; see

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also Fung and Wright, 2003). In Porto Alegre the rules successfully balanced different logics. For example, the rules combined majoritarian democracy in voting for delegates, but with a rotation of offices. They offered prioritization according to expressed needs, but with distribution according to technical knowledge of measured need in weighing funding allocations. The rules also offered separation of roles and powers at various levels of decision-making – for example, separating those who set agendas from those who implement and monitor decisions (Gret and Sintomer, 2005: 44–52). The act of creating democratic rules for themselves can have a functional overspill that allows participants to take ownership of, and advance, even more innovative solutions to democratic dilemmas. Abers shows that in the districts that she observed, citizens eventually took ownership of developing rules themselves that fostered and institutionalized solidarity and democratic norm formation (2000: 179). The separation of rule-making from the application of those rules emulated some original liberal democratic practices that have, lamentably, been lost in modern legislatures, and Nuñez (2018) explains that it was the breakdown of these delicate balances that led to the demise of PB in Porto Alegre.

The appeal of institutional redesign in PB in Porto Alegre is not limited to those obsessed only with how a process might achieve a relatively narrow conception of deliberative empowerment of participants. For instance, Santos (2005) remarks on five different observable changes, including changes to bureaucratic organization; methods of distribution; representative accountability; autonomy of participatory institutions; and accommodating competing legitimacies of inclusion and representative expertise. Many observers have been attracted to PB in the first instance because it achieves distributional justice (more so than democracy per se). That aim was certainly embedded from the beginning in PT objectives and in the PB rules (Santos, 2005: 325). The relationship between democracy and equality of outcome is a complex one and (although I simplify) leftist sympathizers were traditionally associated with schools of thought that see the equal outcomes preceding democracy and not the other way around. While a detailed discussion of democracy and justice is beyond the scope of this book, the important point about PB in Porto Alegre is that although rules for yearly spending decisions obliged distribution towards poorer regions, these rules were formed and re-formed through public deliberation across various levels of PB (see Santos, 2005: 325–9; Abers, 2000: 180).

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Nevertheless, there are important caveats that point to the need for further work on measurements and comparison of empirical observations. It is interesting that Marquetti et al (2012) report that during the period from 1990 to 2000 in Porto Alegre some measures show relative inequality rising, despite an improvement in absolute conditions of the poor (2012: 79). As they point out, it is likely that this is as a result of a number of external factors, but it puts the overall redistributive potential of strong local economic democracy in perspective. Deliberation in Porto Alegre was never ideal, and was accompanied by other forms of political arbitration (Baiocchi, 2005: 78). Individual participation itself took on some familiar patterns associated with rational-actor models of politics:

> … often people who organised in the effort to resolve immediate needs demobilised once the needs were fulfilled. It took many years for the regional budget forums to initiate serious discussions of broader-based issues such as economic development and city planning, and only a small number of regional budget participants went on to join broader policymaking groups such as the thematic forums. (Abers, 2000: 221)

Although the prerogatives of deliberative theorists may be to narrow the conception of democracy to one that draws its legitimacy from ideal publicity and justification, for many, deliberation is a necessary but not sufficient condition for democracy (Pateman, 2012: 8). PB would never achieve all the necessary goods for ideal conceptions of democracy, or be transformational for all participants. Nevertheless, when compared to the inertia and clientelism all too pervasive in modern societies, it seems to provide some image of what the 'school of democracy' theorists (Pateman, Dewey, 2012) might have had in mind. It is not a 'rosy picture', but it is an improved alternative (see Smith, 2009; Ryan and Smith, 2014).

Before moving on from Porto Alegre, it is important to note that PB became more brittle after the PT lost control of the executive in 2004, and the new administration downgraded its priority and PB was suspended in 2017. There are many lessons in the second half of the Porto Alegre story. Although the persistence of any party in government for a decade or more in a democracy raises its own questions, the PT's defeat owed at least some of its explanation to a process that ignored the significant overhead costs incurred in the expansion of departments and infrastructure in the 1990s (Sintomer et al, 2016: 15). Suspension

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of the PB itself in 2017 came after significant loss of political will, economic centralization in Brazil following financial and political crises, and a consequent rising inability for the already diminished PB to deliver projects (Nuñez, 2018: 521). We must seek to explain what leads to the absence of deepened democracy as well as what creates it, and I turn to that question in the next chapter.

Nuñez provides some instructive recommendations for sustaining participatory practices based on elements of Porto Alegre's elaborate PB design that worked against itself in the long run. As he explains, there was no mechanism for dealing democratically with excessive unmet demands that built up over time. Financial transparency decreased because formal oversight was not effectively institutionalized in the good years (2018: 525–7). Moreover, he highlights two pathologies that have yet to be taken seriously enough by proponents and theorists of many democratic innovations in my experience – first, an under-appreciation for capacity-building, recognizing the differential needs of participants with different capacities, and second, a lack of mechanisms to avoid inevitable oligarchy in any long-term process. Both were relevant in the demise of neighbourhood meetings and removal of term limits for delegates in the process. There was a process of internal and incremental regulatory change that Nuñez characterizes as 'participatory democratic suicide' (2018: 530). I will come back to discuss these issues, and what can be done to avoid the capture of incrementalism, by identifying the combinations of conditions that are associated with the absence of deepened democracy, and ultimately, recommending their avoidance.

The book-length narratives to which I refer here provide a far greater description of events in this case than it would be right for me to reproduce. Both Santos (2005) and Smith (2009) provide clear and full explanations of the entire PB process in Porto Alegre. I could have included even more articles and essays on Porto Alegre, as some have laterally appeared as a result of translations, but a review of the literature would become saturated at this point. My aim is to get across a sense that trained, first-hand observers have done the hard work to communicate a story about how exceptional outcomes relevant to desires for a deepened democracy occurred in Porto Alegre around the turn of the 21st century. They did this by carefully identifying the conditions that appear non-trivial in relation to explaining those exceptional outcomes from those that appear irrelevant or trivial. Their work also provides a clear narrative for us to follow, explaining the quality or degrees of difference in these conditions with respect to accepted or previous norms.

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At this point in the necessarily stylized story of the evolution of PB scholarship, all we have is one exceptional case. The worth of the case studies discussed in this chapter should not be valued solely for their potential contribution to developing more general theories or as a stepping-stone to large-N research. In and of themselves they are inherently valuable because they draw together coherent sets of observations that activate numerous relevant theories. Our attempts to move towards larger-N research over a more systematic range of variables or more circumscribed range of theories can only create a supplementary rather than a comparatively better form of knowledge. Secondary analysis introduces some sources of error while correcting others – a trade-off that seems to be better understood by small-N than large-N researchers, in my experience. We must inevitably move up the ladder of abstraction without stretching concepts (Sartori, 1970), and lose some of the detail and understanding of process that can only be garnered by direct observation and intensive treatment of a single case. Nevertheless 'each case is only a case, and it is difficult to build any theoretical generalizations from the individual cases' (Peters, 2013: 167). This is especially true when it is not made clear what the case is a case of – or at least, when the focus is primarily on how a case *departs* from a class of cases. In what follows I will discuss new ways of increasing the number of cases we can coherently engage with in one sitting, with the aim of harnessing rather than replacing case-based knowledge. Ethnographies can open doors for several research endeavours.

How comparison follows from a single case

The foundation of scientific research is comparison. Scholarly work that appears superficially to be a study of a single case almost always involves systematic comparisons of elements within the case as well as implicit or explicit comparison with other known cases. Both Abers and Baiocchi have a comparative element to their study at the city-district level – Abers chose to focus her investigation in the Glória and Extremo do Sul district, with Baiocchi similarly comparing three districts. Both utilize a most-different case selection strategy comparing districts with varying degrees of clientelistic practices. Their selection of districts for comparison means that they can explain more systematically outcomes that depend on whether civil society was in a more positive or negative frame of health from the outset of PB. Also, as I have outlined, they chose to study PB in Porto Alegre in a context of useful background knowledge of other cases. Abers, for instance, suggests the failure of similar early efforts at PB in Brasília were probably down to the PT

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neglecting to make participation a central element of their political strategy – thus the beginnings of inductive musings on some general theories are evident here. Comparison is the method at the heart of both theory generation and testing the scope and proper application of theories. As John Stuart Mill more eloquently put it, 'as the general conception is itself obtained by a comparison of particular phenomena, so, when obtained, the mode in which we apply it to other phenomena is again by comparison' (1950: 298).

There is no getting away from the appearance of exceptionality that motivates and attracts interest in Porto Alegre. Baiocchi, at one point, describes it as 'the Mecca of the Left' (2005: 157). Its conditions are relatively extreme. Further, even if we can find similar cases in other cities nationally, many accounts are quick to emphasize the unique circumstances within Brazil. Authors highlight, for instance, an extraordinarily patrimonial political culture where votes are exchanged for the most basic of material promises; the effect of rapid urbanization as unprecedented swathes of rural poor moved to cities, leading to large unplanned settlements (favelas); and a new set of political institutions and opportunities in the wake of the democratic transition with the opening up of the political opportunity structure following the demise of the military regime (see Santos, 2005: 208–9; Abers, 2000: 26–8; Pont, 2004: 115; Gret and Sintomer, 2005: 14–15). In many ways Porto Alegre is an archetype for subsequent cases of democratic innovation within and without Brazil, and we will have more to say about the methodological implications for comparison.

Nevertheless, perceived exceptionalism is as good a reason as any around which to organize comparison. The rich descriptions of exceptionalism earlier in the chapter have often led to arguments that other cases cannot 'meaningfully' be compared with cases like Porto Alegre or cases in Brazil because conditions are extreme. Many will be used to the scholarly caution of comparing apples with oranges or pears or with other sorts of fruit. Yet too often nowadays the caution is erroneously seen as a justification for not comparing things that do not appear relatively similar. The caution actually exists to ensure the comparativist is sensitive to issues of conceptualization and measurement when they compare and make inference, but the comparison itself is necessary to understand the issues. We need to regularly compare apples with apples, pears, oranges, parliaments, and all sorts, so we know what's what. The important point is that 'if the study is conducted outside a comparative framework, it is easy for the researcher to make a number of assumptions about the exceptionalism of the case' (Peters, 2013: 4). Without a relatively comprehensive

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comparative framework the exceptionalism and its degree in Porto Alegre is more assumed than analysed and understood. Too often 'comparability' is used as an excuse. It is used either to justify asking inanely boring research questions to cover many similar observations while offering careful controls but results of no practical use, or for avoiding any increase in observations and consoling oneself with the comfort of assumption. Systematic cumulation of existing studies, even where different kinds of data extraction have been employed, despite imperfections, is preferable (or at least a necessary complement) to other kinds of research strategies.

The news of the Porto Alegre case certainly inspired others to think about how it related to alternative institutional innovations, knowledge of which, as we saw, began to spread. Notable among them were those interested in real-world applications of democratic theory, for example, Fung (2003), Fung and Wright (2003) and Smith (2009). Their work looks at very innovative, but very different, institutional designs, and they draw parallels across different democratic institutions, showing that there are multiple practical ways to realize the democratic goods heralded by abstract theories. The cases that Fung and Smith discuss in their work tend to be of this variety – ground-breaking innovations in participatory institution-building that embody diverse theoretical principles of democracy. Theirs is effectively a most-different systems design following closely the logic of Mill's method of agreement. Using the initial organizing principle of divergence from a less democratic norm as a common outcome, they select several different cases that achieve novel democratic deepening and try and draw some similarities across the cases while documenting many differences.

That work is essential reading and foundational to the subfield that has emerged to study PDIs, but is not without its problems. If the first cases brought to attention are all those with exceptional outcomes, we might expect that a typical case should not be so exceptional. If we are too focused on exceptionalism, we cannot be sure of what the typical case looks like and how it differs from our exceptional ones. We would expect that, much like in Galton's original understanding of the statistical problem, the child of the exceptional parent (say, the Porto Alegre archetype) would regress towards the mean. As Spada and Ryan point out,

> … the problem here is that we don't have a good sense of a population and we don't know what the mean might look like. If we took a sample of participatory processes over time, we would probably expect that the results in Porto Alegre were atypical. (Spada and Ryan, 2017: 774)

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> … without sampling carefully to uncover evidence for causality we do not know that the factors identified as crucial to explaining the cases' successes in these early accounts, if removed, would be recognised to some extent as artefacts of the order in which they were encountered …. This does not take away from … pioneering work but it warns us to continue down the road of research cumulation before getting too excited. (Ryan, 2019: 562)

Perhaps more quickly than analysts could publish their (mostly positive) reviews of Porto Alegre's experiences, PB was diffusing and being taken up by other governments at an encouraging rate. This was thanks in no small part to committed activists in various fora and networks (Porto de Oliveira, 2017). Their efforts were boosted by Porto Alegre's relationship with the World Social Forum, and in another way by endorsements from the World Bank and the UN (Goldfrank, 2012). Many writers speak of waves of diffusion as PB spread first across Brazil, then Latin America, later to Europe and North America and further east, even to non-democracies (Cabannes, 2004; Sintomer et al, 2013). Developments then saw an increasing uptake in the US. PB diffusion is often characterized by adaptation of the model to local conditions, with individual actors playing a strong influential role. One of Röcke's unique contributions to the literature is to show the multi-level character of PB diffusion through different channels and actors who then adapt PB to both local conditions and national 'frames' of political participation in implementation (2014). This is food for thought for those interested in scoping a population of worldwide participatory budgets for comparison and generalizations. There have been notable attempts to track, index or generalize the 'who, what, why, and where' of diffusion of PB around the world (see, variously, Cabannes, 2004; Sintomer et al, 2005, 2008, 2010, 2012, 2013, 2016; Shah, 2007; Herzberg, 2011; Goldfrank, 2012; Dias, 2014, 2018; Röcke, 2014; Baiocchi and Ganuza, 2016; Porto de Oliveira, 2017; Cabannes and Lipietz, 2018). Building on that work, the primary aim of this book is to establish what effects important differences in implementation and context have had on the empowerment of citizens, and what causal inference we can engage in using advanced tools for logical induction and deduction.

Despite some heated debate (and dogma), I think it is safe to say that social scientists are made aware in the course of their training of some of the limitations in drawing general conclusions from a single case study. More interestingly, I think, social scientists should also be

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sensitive to the availability bias 'which anchors their understanding of what kinds of cases are possible to what kinds of cases they are aware of at any point in time' (Ryan, 2019: 562). Our perceptions are bound and shaped by the order in which information is received (for example, which cases we hear of first and then later), and there is a collective path dependency if a single case is held to be archetypal. Despite all best intentions and training in scientific methods, there are many mixed incentives that can guide case selection:

> Scholarly reputations are made by claiming a case is unique or at least unusual, and that makes cumulation difficult. Claims of uniqueness, however, are sometimes overstated, and if cases are examined together then there is the capacity to create some generalisations out of apparently disparate cases … even with all the potential problems, cumulation of case materials is preferable to no cumulation …. (Peters, 2013: 170)

The key lesson of science is that the information that reaches you in your life is biased, and the scholarly mission is to reduce that bias through a set of techniques and protocols. In social science it can be argued that we need more vigilance, and a wider complement of perspectives, knowledge and techniques because the truth (if there is *one*) is more difficult to ascertain as experimental conditions are rare or impossible. As Keith Dowding puts it, 'Social science is not rocket science. It's much harder than that' (2016: 249). As PB moved beyond the Porto Alegre 'exception', how have PB scholars dealt with this mission up to now?

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